

Military Hotels

Restaurants that preserve Bengaluru's non vegetarian food culture

If you've ever found yourself in a BMTC bus, head lazily resting on the window, looking out at the moving city - you might have come across banners titled 'military hotels'. And maybe just for a second your brain goes "huh, I wonder what those are". I mean sure, you probably figure instantaneously that it's some sort of an eatery - but why is it called that? Is it different in some way? or is it no more than just a quirky differentiable name?

Normally dozens of questions like these pass through our heads day to day but writing this article meant we could actually afford to dig into an *apparently* silly question like this. So we asked around for the best place in town and off we went, to Shivaji Military Hotel - which is supposed to be the oldest in the city, established in 1908 by Manji Rao. But the glamour of history and vintage of the establishment would not be evident at first glance.

The first thing you would experience in fact, is the weight of you having signed yourself up for a half an hour wait *minimum*. You'd look with angst at flocks of people - office workers, families, groups of teens, buzz in and out of this dingy place like bees around a honeycomb. Your dreadful wait would be made to seem interminable by the aromas of large vessels of mutton curries simmering in the kitchen.

For many of these patrons, these military hotels are simply places where you can find good non-vegetarian food. But if we dig a little, it tells us a story about the city's food history, social makeup and its culture. The term "military hotel" is itself unique to southern India - particularly in Karnataka, Tamil Nadu and Andhra Pradesh. Despite the word hotel in name, it refers only to a type of eatery and not accommodation. The name, a remnant of how hotels and restaurants are used interchangeably in received Indian English vernaculars.

Today when we discuss Bengaluru's food culture, we talk about all of the accoutrements associated with a cosmopolitan metropolis - global cuisines, cafes, breweries and fine dining - but one may easily overlook military hotels, an important remnant of old Bengaluru's food culture, before it became the cosmopolis it is today. They preserve a tradition of certain dishes and recipes that might otherwise disappear. How many restaurants have you been to where they serve nalli soup? or boti fry? They preserve and allow continued access to nutrient dense offals that are quite unique to our part of the world.

In fact there is a saying in some Tamil non-vegetarian households. **கொன்ற பாவம் தின்றால் போகும்** (KonRa paavam thindRal pOgum) - it means the sin acquired by killing an animal, goes away when you consume it. Now the ethics of killing an animal for food is beyond the scope of this article - but there's one thing we can be sure about - if we do end up killing an animal, the least we could do is use as much of it as possible - to not waste it. Wasting food is unacceptable in and of itself, but this virtue is even more important when it comes to animal foods, something that is ingrained into some south indian cultures which

viewed eating the animal whole - including the internal organs, as a virtue - respecting the animal whose life we took to eat. In the modern world all of the offals - the internal organs are discarded, retaining only the meat from flesh because it is no longer the widespread culture to eat such meats. Children are not used to eating them and they grow up to be meat eating adults who simply cannot start eating it at a later stage. These Military hotels are one of the channels through which this indigenous culture persists.

Most people looking toward south indian food culture ostensibly associate us with vegetarian food for some reason. Perhaps just a sampling bias due to the caste makeup and dynamics of our country. Most prominent and visible south Indians have historically come from upper castes - who have sanskritized, even their diets. It leads to a unique phenomenon, where families cook only pure vegetarian meals on religious observations and important festivals while meat still makes a part of their regular diet - making it unintentionally appear as though all diet is vegetarian during visible important days.

Military hotels are one of those bastions that help continue the dietary tradition of the underrepresented majority. Foods such as nalli soup - a collagen rich bone broth, that has to be slow cooked for several hours, is often impractical to cook in individual homes. Cleaning and cooking offals is also a very time consuming and a malodorous affair - a situation that is ripe for utilising economies of scale - military hotels allow people to get access to such foods that are very difficult to prepare at home regularly.

Why are they called “military hotels?”

There is no single veritable origin of the name, but food historians and journalists converge onto a few factors that contributed to the name.

In popular understanding, meat consumption was associated with soldiers, police personnel, laborers, hunters, and communities engaged in physically demanding work. Perhaps anecdotally associating higher protein foods with muscle even if terminologies were not known. Therefore the word "military" became shorthand for a place where non-vegetarian food was served.

Another explanation relates to the nature of the food itself. During the colonial period many eating establishments in cities were primarily vegetarian, catering to the mostly vegetarian upper class. Such hotels, often run by Brahmin communities, dominated the public dining space in several towns and cities. Restaurants serving meat needed a way to clearly distinguish themselves.

Another explanation connects the name to military cantonments. According to food historian Suresh Jayaram, when the Maratha army occupied Bengaluru in the 1600s, it helped give rise to military hotels that met soldiers' high-protein needs. British military cantonments attracted large populations of soldiers, support staff, transport workers, traders, and migrants. Some eateries developed around these settlements and served people connected to military life, with

delicacies they enjoyed and served as gathering spaces for the soldiery outside their cantonments. They were started for and sometimes by military personnel. Over time, restaurants serving substantial meat-based meals acquired the "military" label regardless of them having any direct relationship with the armed forces.

The term eventually evolved into a category of restaurant rather than a description of ownership. A military hotel has come to mean an affordable establishment specializing in country style non vegetarian food . The name has remained even if its original associations faded.

What's so different about these eateries?

What distinguishes military hotels from other eateries most clearly is their food. Although their menus vary from place to place, certain characteristics are retained across all. First, meat occupies the central position. Mutton (red meat) is often the defining ingredient. Chicken became increasingly common over time, but mutton remains closely associated with the military hotel identity. Soldiers and martial tradition in general in the olden days used to associate eating larger animals with greater strength. Many establishments are also known for dishes using cuts and preparations that rarely appear in upscale restaurants.

Second, the cooking style emphasizes quality of basics rather than complexity of preparation - what we colloquially call 'naati style' or country style. Spice blends are prepared in-house. Gravies rely on slow cooking rather than having a complex blend of ingredients and multiple cooking styles and elaborate garnishes. The result is food designed to satisfy the belly of a hungry patron than to impress them.

Third, menus are typically concise. Rather than offering dozens of dishes, many military hotels focus on a smaller number of specialties. This concentration allows consistency and efficiency. Most customers who come here know exactly what to order. And once you manage to get a table, you barely have to wait for the food to arrive after placing the order. The approach is sharply different from contemporary restaurant culture, where extensive menus and constant innovation are frequently viewed as signs of quality.

'Hindu' Military hotels?

Some military hotels in Bengaluru have the prefix "Hindu" in their names, for example Rajanna Hindu Military Hotel. This isn't necessarily a declaration of religion but a statement about the menu — a reassurance that the establishment does not serve beef or pork. In Hindu communities cows are sacred, while in muslim communities pork is avoided; the prefix signalled an intention to be acceptable to a broad range of customers.

The traditional signature, Donne Biryani — served in dried areca leaves called "donne" — grew from a need to serve large groups (soldiers and labourers) using locally available

implements and eventually became a cultural signifier. Its subtler spices and characteristic green presentation differentiates it from other biryanis in India.

Ragi Mudde is another staple: a dense millet ball made from finger millet that was historically valued for its nutrition and resilience in dry conditions. Paired with a robust meat curry, it offered affordable, sustaining meals for workers and soldiers.

Offal dishes — bheja fry (brain), kaleji (liver), paya (trotter), and boti (intestines) — were common because they were inexpensive and abundant. Over time they became distinctive flavours of the experience and remain cherished by its patrons today.

As Bangalore transformed into a major city, new eateries and lifestyle venues opened up, and military hotels had to adapt. They continue to serve as sites of memory and continuity for long-time residents with the iconic dishes while still offering new generations with newer varieties withholding some space for the city's culinary past.

For many people, these eateries hold cherished memories: childhood meals, neighbourhood rituals, and communal dining with friends and family around banana leaves. For others it's the discovery of a living culinary tradition, one that continues to shape Bengaluru's food culture.

Why do Military Hotels still matter?

Military hotels continue to be important because they represent a model of urban food culture that prioritizes *continuity*, *accessibility*, and *local identity*. They preserve foods that may very well otherwise disappear. They provide an affordable option in a city where eating out is becoming increasingly expensive. Most importantly they provide a space where various classes of people can sit together in a simple non-glamorous space without any stigma - and make dining more about the meal than the luxurious experience surrounding it.

Bengaluru's culinary culture rests on many influences, from Udupi restaurants and darshinis to cafés and breweries - and military hotels play an integral part along with them. Their story is a story about how our city eats, unique to us. It is a story created by migration, workers (both armed forces and civilians), family entrepreneurship and regional traditions and tastes. It is about how our food moved from our villages into urban life. And it is about institutions that have survived for a long time because they stuck by something important to them rather than chase trends.